

The last newspaper I read

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“Sometimes I wish I had said hi to her” was the only thought that lingered in my mind as I sat in peace facing the endless sea in front of me , waiting for my turn to go. I tried to convince myself that this thought will soon be washed away , just like the tea residue that settles at the bottom of the cup, having served its purpose and waiting patiently to be washed away. But for reasons that i cannot fathom, this residue stuck to my heart, as if it was irremovable. Funny how a man’s mind works in the bliss of solitude.

I closed my eyes for a moment , took a deep breath and slowly started to take in the majestic beauty of the world that surrounded me. Anything that would distract me from thinking about her was the only prescription I needed now. Far to the distant west, I saw a star that was blessing its child with the grace of warmth. An entity that was slowly burning itself to death, working rigorously without complaining to keep its offspring warm. Reminded me of some people, my family. The orange glowing circular beacon of light had started to cast a nice red shadow in the endless blue sea, the greatest creation of god.

The sea was calm, the water was still, and it lay flat as if it were a canvas, patiently waiting for an artist to splash life into it. Now the canvas was filled with splashes of colors that could bring happiness to souls that traverse it to reach a world far beyond. The reddish - orange shadow nicely mixed with the blue , slowly fading away as the blue made its way to the land.

The land - a purified mass of white serenity - lay there cuddling the calm blue sea as if both were in the deepest sleep, free of all the torments and sorrows which one has to encounter when there is light in one’s eyes. The snow was fluffy , pure white with an angelic tone, crumbling in my palm, but it was warm. It felt to me like I was at a feast where everyone dressed well and kept everyone in good company. But the sky and the wind were absent. I guess they were not invited or they were too ashamed to come.

I sat there alone in silence, facing the bliss of happiness in front of me that was giving me the greatest joy to my eyes, a celebration created for someone to just contemplate his life so far. In that moment of solitude, my mind was weary. Of all the thoughts that I could have been thinking about, her smile was only the image that my brain could process. I remember the first time I saw her.

Life was easy back then , it had a direction unlike now. I sat there in the crowd watching the elegant performance of my fellow beings, who were vehemently trying to inflict the joy in the gazing eyes of the audience. Unlike the festivity in front of me , they had to put in some effort. In the crowd, I felt like an unattended pawn in chess, that the master is keeping aside a sacrificial lamb for the king to live long. I heard a sharp but feeble voice from my back, saying “hi”. I turned back in the

hope of greeting a female fellow being. For a boy in his early 20s , greeting a girl for the first time gave him a feeling that cannot be put in words. A mixture of emotions that needs to be filtered to fully understand what is going through his mind . I was ready for my feelings to be filtered, a small smile started to appear in my lips as I slowly turned back taking a puff of air from lady earth ready to give it back to her by uttering the word “hi”. Before I could say anything , a female voice welcomed her back. That “hi” was not meant for me. The two women exchanged greetings and left the room , leaving me in the state I was already in, an unattended pawn. I felt ashamed at that time, but the thought that no one saw it was a great relief. My heart was at ease thinking of it. I turned back to look at the stage, then I saw a girl who smiled at me, then turned to her friends who were sitting alongside her, and started explaining the whole ordeal I just had. They laughed at my expense. She turned back to me and said “hi”. I just smiled , got up and felt. *Sometimes I wish I had said hi to her at that time.*

From then on, life went as normal, days made its way to nights, nights to days, weeks to months. Time just went along. But the silly encounter of mine still lingered in my heart. One fine evening, as I was strolling through my campus, with no purpose at all, my mind was focused on some matter of academic interest. Although I knew I was better suited to sit at a desk with a pen and paper at that time, I felt like walking, ignoring everything in front of me - me and just my thoughts. My treads led me to a narrow passage. I slowly slowed my pace and carefully started to make my way through it. My eyes were locked on the ground, a canvas covered in dirt. I heard the sound of an anklet , moving towards me. As I raised my gaze from the dirty canvas to look at who was in front of me, I saw a girl, the same girl whose greeting I stood up that day. There she was standing right in front of me. Her eyes were locked at the dirty canvas, with her small steps she carefully carried her small feeble body through the passage ignoring all life around her. I saw her for the first time up close. My heart pumped, I could feel my hands tremble, a mixture of emotions that one cannot explain. My entire body wanted to greet her as if she were its queen. As she came close to me, with her eyes still locked on the ground, I greeted her with a few words, which to date I regret saying. *Sometimes I wish I had just said hi to her.* Although my body was ready to greet her, my mind had other plans.

Long dark hair, tied in an elegant knot, covering some portion of her ear, with one lazy strand falling right into her face. Eyebrows nicely surrounding her round brown eyes separated from one another by a tone of cream tone skin. Small facial hairs dotting here and there near her wine red lips. A beautiful young woman. As she passed me, I blurted out : “Oh god, she looks like an angel”. These words that I had always wanted to retract. On hearing this, she immediately lifted her head to look at the person who just hit on her, and our eyes locked for the first time. The romantic it may look, it was not romantic at all. I could feel my soul leaving my body. I could have beaten myself to death at that moment. For the entirety of my life, I frowned on men who cat-fished women, and here I was making such comments to a young lady right in front of her. I quickly turned my gaze back to the dirty canvas and started to walk away quickly, ignoring my safety. What more damage can I do to myself from now on? I felt like I had cheated on me.

From then on, I questioned my entire existence. From my childhood on, certain principles were bestowed upon me. Principles that my parents gave me before they left this world many years ago when I was still a teenager. The life of a person is an event made up of several instances. How each event builds up will depend on how one behaves during each instance. There is no ideal way to behave, but one’s principles will guide one to a safe spot that would make one’s life and the other’s life peaceful; that is how a society works. “Treat a woman in the way you want others to treat your sister”, one of those principles that I had been following for years. The very thought of washing

down the drain one of my own principles questioned my nature as a man. It is a known fact , each human has an animal living inside them - a basic instinct. Using these so-called principles, we try to subdue the animal within us. But after this incident , I started to think my basic instinct was to flirt or to hit on any beautiful women my eyes set-forth on. Never in a million years would I have thought I would have thrown myself under the bus because of a woman.

From then on, I lived with the constant fear that I would be beaten up by her male friends for making her feel uncomfortable. I characterized myself as a pervert. Now in this blissful moment of solitude, I started to laugh. It is funny how a person behaves when entering unknown territories. During the time, I was busy punishing myself with harsh criticisms of behavior, cupid had started to do his work. Unknowingly, I started to fall for her. There was a constant ache in my heart to see her every day. Her smile, her cute face, her short steps, her sweet hellos are a few things I wanted to have everyday when I woke up that time. From then on, my life felt different. It is true when the poet said that unrequited love stings the most. As I crossed every corridor, as I made my way through a crowd, my eyes were always on a continuous mission searching for her. I just wanted to see her. Literally, I was “soft” stalking here. Although it felt creepy, there was some purity in it. I wanted to know her, explain the whole ordeal we had and be with her always.

Time flew as always, my life went on. On a sunny early morning, as usual, I went to the library to read the daily newspaper. Although access to the same can be obtained through a simple mobile click; I preferred the old-fashion way. There was something special about morning paper : crisp sheets, nicely folded with a special smell, and the sound of turning the papers, all in 16 pages. I didn't really care for the contents in the paper, it was just the pleasure of reading in the morning library that attracted me the most. Calmness mixed with the right amount of solitude and over seasoned with silence, a perfect recipe for a morning person like me. On that day , I sat down with my newspaper, greeting all the familiar faces that I see everyday. But there was an uninvited guest; she was sitting across me, gazing through the newspaper. My heart just missed a beat. I stood up with the intention to leave. I walked to the exit only to be stopped by the librarian , who greeted me. He started to talk to me about a book that he found quite intriguing. My mind was lost, I could not really understand what he was telling me. I just wanted him to stop talking, then he asked “are you leaving already?”, as a librarian, he was well aware of my daily library routines and my taste in books. In panic, I said “No, I was going to get my water bottle”. I went into the bag room to get my bottle, and on my way back to the entrance, our small discussion continued, with him doing most of the talking. We parted our way, I nervously entered the library alone and made my way to my usual stop, to find the desk empty. My newspaper was lying there flat in the empty desk. She had left. It was a sigh of relief for me , but I was sad for some reason. *Sometimes I wish I had said hi to her that day.* From then on, she became a regular for the morning newspaper routine. We never met or even locked eyes. But we were aware of one another's presence. Now my morning routine had an aim: to see her.

Weeks passed, but this routine remained the same. Her angelic gaze was the only thing I wanted at that time. For some reason, I started to make my own theories about her morning visits to the library. Well, one of these theories was that she was preparing for some competitive exams , based on the newspaper she read everyday, it made sense or she was here because she wanted to see someone. I wanted to believe in the latter and that someone to be me. Did she have feelings for me? , this was one question that I kept asking myself daily. The thought of the same gave me chills. I started to build up mental scenarios in my head, what if she comes and talks to me, what if she likes me, what if she didn't like me, etc. For all these scenarios, I was not prepared and I did

not want to prepare myself. I was content with what I had, just seeing her smile gave me mental peace that nothing in this world could ever give. But one morning , my mind changed. Time had done its trick. It was time for me to temporarily leave the institute for one year. By the time I come back, I knew she would have left the institute. I had to confess my feelings to her that day itself.

My flight was at 10 am, given all the packing left and the road trip, I had a narrow window of half an hour to spend for my morning library visit. I mentally prepared that day. I rehearsed all my lines, I was as ready as I could. To meet my dear one and confess my feeling. The only thing I was not ready for was the consequences of my action. What if she rejects me or what if she accepts me, I did not really think at that point of time, I just wanted to pour my heart out to her and see where it goes. Once again nervously I entered the library, greeting the librarian, all the familiar faces, and sat down in my usual spot. I started to scan the library; she hadn't arrived yet. I patiently waited for her. Time ticked by, I got really nervous, it was almost an hour since I had an open newspaper in front of me, the water bottle that I carried with me was empty. Now I couldn't wait longer, I had a flight to catch. With a deep breath, I composed myself and said to myself: "This is life". I ran to my room to continue packing. Her face slowly started to vanish away from my heart.

I got on the plane on time. The thought of seeing my family after a long time made me feel better. A young boy was sitting next to me. He had some comics with him. He was in his own world , reading the book and picturing himself as the hero. He made sure to use his physical body to indicate what he was thinking. I knew this would be a long flight for me. I didn't want to tell the child that I am also a comic book fan. The only thing I wanted now was to be alone. Her thoughts were long dead buried for me. People were still boarding the flight, there was a lot of commotion at the start of the journey, initially the flight was cancelled due to bad weather , but it was rescheduled again an hour late, so the people who went back home had to come back. There was a lot of confusion, apparently due to poor management. As I made myself comfortable in my seat, I scanned the flight for familiar faces, an action that every human does for unknown reasons. I didn't expect anyone, but in two rows in front of me, I saw someone, it was her!, sitting right there in this flight. I thought to myself that she might have seen me enter. This is fate, does the world want us to be together. My heart went chill.

The snow in my hand suddenly went cold. I threw it away, the sun was almost setting. It seemed to me that reality was setting in for me now. The warm snow was getting cold, the sun started to hide, the water was no longer still, a small breeze blew and the wind finally arrived at the feast as an uninvited guest. His presence was not liked by the remaining attendees for obvious reasons. I stood up and continued my thoughts. On the plane, I was nervous what to do now. I started mentally to prepare. I planned to talk to her after the flight lands, exchange our numbers, and see where it goes. I could not focus on the in-flight movie that was playing, my eyes were on her. She was completely invested in her movie. I looked up and prayed to God if I could sit next to her. God comes in various forms; for me, it was in the form of a comic book boy. Out of no where , the boy started to cry for his mother, the stewardess came to calm him down, but he kept on crying. After 10 minutes of tantrum, the boy got what he wanted, his mother, who happened to be a cabin crew member on the flight. She came and apologized to me, she then made seat arrangements, so that her child would always be close to her. As a result of her motherly love, my dear one was now sitting next to me. Now I was ready. I had already rehearsed my lines that morning, I was looking for the right time to say hi to her and pour out my heart.

I felt a gentle hand on my shoulder. My thoughts were broken, blood rushed through my veins, my

heart went cold, my limbs switched off. The same feeling when she kept her hand on my arm when I confessed my feelings to her. My chaperone had arrived. The sky was lit with stars. The sun had almost left, the sea was dancing left and right, and the snow was slowly turning dark. The reality was hitting. He smiled at me and pointed my attention to someone who was leaving. In the far horizon , I saw her leaving in her boat, her chaperone was gently rowing the boat to the horizon. Her image was slowly fading , but I could clearly see her face , she was smiling at me. I smiled at her back and lipped the word “hi”, she also lipped the same. I closed my eyes for a second, took a deep breath and turned to my chaperone , to signal I am ready. we both walk silently to our small boat. I got into it and we started our journey. The water was still now. The wind and sky stood there, doing nothing as if they were apologizing to me. I was in peace.

The chaperone grabbed my attention once again , he gave me a nice crisp folded newspaper and pointed to the water. I looked down at the majestic sea, to see many familiar faces. I saw my sister, sitting next to my soulless body , crying her lungs out. She was eagerly waiting for my arrival, she was a parent to me, who sacrificed her youth to take care of me. Seeing her cry made me a bit sad, but I knew that this was better for her. I saw her future in the water, a wonderful life awaits her, a future without me holding her back. Peace was restored again. I smiled at the chaperone who was curiously gazing at me.

Now I turned my attention to the newspaper, carefully unfolded the paper, and started to scan it. I saw my photo near her, with the title “The last survivors of the air crash breathe their last ’ , I shook my head and smiled. I closed and kept aside , the last newspaper that I read in this lifetime and turned to the chaperone and asked “Were we meant to be together in this life ” . The chaperone just smiled and said, “ You and her are already together ”. The sun was beautiful up and close, I could see new light in my eyes , my memories started to fade away slowly. I was ready for my new life, I stood up , looked at my chaperone, and said to him : “*Sometimes I wish I had said hi to her back then...*”

—The End—